

Habanero Braised Short Ribs

Birria-adjacent braise — cumin & smoked-paprika crust, charred-habanero cola jus, tuned for slow-building back-palate heat.

SERVINGS
3 (1 rib = 1 serving)

ACTIVE
~35 min

BRAISE
3 hr

HEAT
Serious, slow build

Ingredients

THE RIBS & RUB

1.5 lb	boneless beef short rib (three 0.5 lb ribs)
1 tbsp	light olive oil (for the sear — not extra-virgin)
1 tbsp	garlic powder
1 tbsp	onion powder
1 tbsp	smoked paprika
1 tbsp	ground cumin
1 tsp	black pepper
1 tsp	ground allspice
2 tsp	MSG
scant 1 tsp	fine table salt (~5 g — weigh it)
1 tbsp	light brown sugar

THE JUS

1 cup	low-sodium beef stock
1/2 cup	Cherry Coke
2 tsp	fish sauce
1 tbsp	tomato paste
2	habaneros, whole & intact
1	medium onion, halved
4	garlic cloves
1	bay leaf
1	strip of orange peel (zest only, no pith)
1	lime, juiced (finish)
—	flaky Maldon salt, to finish at the table

Method

1

Rub & dry-cure

Mix the garlic powder, onion powder, smoked paprika, cumin, black pepper, allspice, MSG, fine table salt, and brown sugar into a rub. Coat the ribs on all sides. Rest on a rack, uncovered, in the fridge for a full 20 hr — don't shortcut this; the long dry-cure is what penetrates the meat and dries the surface for a hard sear. Pull from the fridge 30–45 min before searing and pat the surface dry.

2

Char the aromatics · 9 min

In a dry cast iron over high heat, blacken the halved onion, garlic cloves, and habaneros until blistered and spotty-black — char, not ash. Keep the habaneros whole and intact (don't cut or seed them); prick each once or twice with a knife tip so they release slowly. Set all the charred aromatics aside on a plate — they go back in at Step 6.

3

Sear the ribs · 8 min

Add the olive oil to the same cast iron and sear the ribs hard on every face until deep brown. Pull the ribs. Do not rush this — the fond left behind is the base of the whole jus.

4

Bloom the tomato paste · 1 min 30 sec

Drop the tomato paste into the fond and stir over medium-high until it darkens from bright red to brick-rust and smells sweet-roasty, about 90 seconds.

5

Deglaze with cola · 4 min

Pour in the Cherry Coke, scrape up the fond, and reduce by half. This cooks off the raw fizz-sweetness and concentrates the cola into something intentional.

6

Return aromatics & build the braise · 3 min

Return the charred onion, garlic, and whole habaneros to the cast iron, along with the beef stock, fish sauce, bay leaf, and orange peel. Stir to combine and bring just up to a simmer over medium heat (~2–3 min). This is NOT a reduction — you're only combining and heating through. Transfer the ribs and all the liquid to a 9x13 Pyrex; liquid should come partway up the ribs, not cover them. Crimp foil tight over the rim, keeping it from ballooning.

7

Braise · 3 hr

Breville at 300°F convection, foil sealed, for a full 3 hr. Check for fork-tenderness at the 3 hr mark — the meat should give with no resistance.

8

Strain gently & reduce on the stovetop · 12 min

Pull the ribs. Strain the jus GENTLY into a clean saucepan (a fresh pot, not the cast iron) — let it drain on its own, do NOT press the solids. Skim LIGHT, leaving a fuller fat layer: the fat is what time-releases the back-palate heat. Set the saucepan on the stovetop over medium-high and simmer-reduce until the jus coats the back of a spoon.

9

Finish & salt

Off heat, stir in the lime juice. Salt the jus to taste — second salting stage, add incrementally since fish sauce and rub salt are already stacked in. Spoon over the ribs and finish the sliced meat with a pinch of flaky Maldon at the table.

1

Store

Store the meat submerged in its jus — the liquid keeps it moist and seals it from air. Wide-mouth mason jars are ideal; cool to room temp first, then lid and refrigerate. Keeps 3–4 days in the fridge, or freeze up to 3 months (leave headspace for expansion).

1

Reheat

Stovetop (best): low and covered in its jus; add a splash of stock if the jus set thick. **Microwave (fastest):** short bursts, stirring between. **Breville / toaster oven:** meat and jus in an oven-safe dish, covered with foil, on Reheat or Bake at 300°F — pull when the jus bubbles at the edges and the meat is warmed through, ~15–20 min from cold. Uncover the last 2–3 min only if you want the edges to tighten. Always gentle and low.

Chef's Notes
Dialing the heat

The slow, lingering, back-palate burn comes from three things working together: whole intact habaneros braised the full time (gradual diffusion, not a raw spike); a gentle strain with no pressing (pressing forces sharp concentrated heat back in); and a fuller fat layer left in the jus (capsaicin is fat-soluble, so the rendered fat time-releases the burn). Want it hotter? Go to 3 whole pods — same smooth register, more linger.

Three-stage salting

Fine table salt in the rub (~5 g), salt the finished jus to taste, then flaky Maldon on the sliced meat. That's how braised beef reads seasoned all the way through, not just on the crust. Rub salt is dialed to meat weight, so it doesn't scale with the aromatic rub — hold it at ~5 g. Maldon stays as the finishing salt only.

Vessels, in order

Cast iron does the char, sear, bloom, and deglaze (Steps 2–5). Everything moves to the 9x13 Pyrex for the braise. The final reduction happens in a clean saucepan on the stovetop.

Per serving (est.)

~440 cal · ~31 g protein · ~31 g fat · ~9 g carbs. The 0.5 lb is raw weight — short rib sheds a good chunk to rendered fat and moisture, so the cooked portion is smaller. Leftovers improve overnight as the heat and flavor integrate; day-two is often the best it tastes.

NO-HEAT VERSION · Omit the habaneros entirely and skip charring them — the heat lives in the pod, not the char, so leaving them out (rather than just un-blistering them) is the only way to lose the burn. You keep the full cola-cumin-citrus braise, just gentle. For a whisper of warmth without real heat, a pinch of the smoked paprika does the lifting.